Movie Maverick: 100 Years of Roger Corman

The Intruder

The Intruder
Director: Roger Corman
Production Company: Los Altos Inc.
Executive Producer: Gene Corman
Producer: Roger Corman
Production Manager: Jack Bohrer
Assistant Director: Steve Bernhardt
[Assistant Director]: Lou Place *
Script Supervisor: Mary Earl Wasem
Screenplay/Original novel: Charles Beaumont
Director of Photography: Taylor Byars
Additional Photography: Haskell Wexler *
Lighting: Lloyd Garnell
Key Grip: Charles Hanawalt
Editor: Ronald Sinclair
Property Master: George Baur
Wardrobe: Dorothy Watson
Make-up: Glen Ault
Music: Herman Stein
Sound: John Bury
Cast:
William Shatner *(Adam Cramer)*
Frank Maxwell *(Tom McDaniels)*
Beverly Lunsford *(Ella McDaniels)*
Robert Emhardt *(Verne Shipman)*
Leo Gordon *(Sam Griffin)*
Charles Barnes *(Joey Green)*
Charles Beaumont *(Harley Paton)*
Katherine Smith *(Ruth McDaniels)*
George Clayton Johnson *(Phil West)*
William Nolan *(Bart Carey)*
Phoebe Rowe *(Mrs Pearl Lambert)*
Bo Dodd *(sheriff)*
Walter Kurtz *(Gramps)*
O.C Ritch *(Jack Allardyce)*
Jeanne Cooper *(Vi Griffin)*
USA 1962
84 mins
Digital

* Uncredited

The screening on Fri 13 Nov will be introduced by Julie Corman, producer and Roger Corman's wife

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The peculiarity of *The Intruder* in Roger Corman's career has been remarked on both before and after the event. In *Sight & Sound*, Summer 1963, the columnist Arkadin, in a piece signalling the delights of Corman's poverty-row 50s films, mentions 'disquieting reports that he has "gone straight", with a new-wave, serious-type drama about colour prejudice.' And in the same magazine, Autumn 1970, Corman in an interview regrets that *The Intruder*, 'which I believed in very much, became too overt, a little too much of a lecture.' The project may have been unusual enough in that it was the first time Corman had tackled a social issue head on (he himself saw it as his first 'serious' picture), and in that it was made on location, mostly in Charleston, Missouri, with the bigotry and simmering violence that the film dramatises often becoming the uncomfortable context in which it was made. The peculiarity, though, is not all that peculiar, since this proto docu-drama approach – the film and its source novel were based on real events that had taken place a few years before in Tennessee – is also another instance of the resourceful and economical Corman adapting to circumstances.

Unable to finance the project either through the major studios or his usual low-budget sources, Corman made the film on $100,000 of his own money (the proceeds of his two recent Poe movies). And he not only shot it in situ, but with a cast of just six professional actors, making up both cast and crew with local recruits. Its 'realism' may be the film's trump card, the atmospheric advantage it derives right from the opening credit sequence of Cramer's bus ride into Caxton, *ciné vérité* images of crumbling poverty on the outskirts of town gradually giving way to the white – indeed bleached-out in the heat – lower-middle-class respectability at its heart. Added to which is the unmistakeable quality which non-professional players (like the burly sheriff who reluctantly steps in to stop the terrorising of a family of out-of-town Blacks) bring to certain scenes, their rawness and awkwardness, their amiable blankness, seeming to contain an unvoiced threat.

But the documentary surfaces of the film don't necessarily add up to a documentary. Often, in fact, and quite fascinatingly, they suggest the opposite: a dramatic minimalism, a film whose emotional and psychological interest has been ruthlessly suppressed – its subject might be that suppression – or allowed only to surface, obliquely as it were, through these social passions. To call this you-are-there report on the violence of desegregation oblique is the key to its true peculiarity, the lack of motivation that connects the intruder Adam Cramer to the racial unrest he stirs up. In a way, it's as if William Shatner's character had picked up on the blankness of the real-life 'performers' who surround him, and reflected it back, demonically (Shatner's own performance is a remarkable portrait of a demagogue and his quicksilver changes of mood and mask). But it's impossible to tell what passions motivate this smiling, white-suited figure who insists on being everyone's friend. Not surprisingly, they all initially take him for a salesman and he's eventually bested by a professional in the field (Leo Gordon), who knows a mask when it's sliding by him.

It's unclear if Cramer himself is a racist; his pleasure is in working on the emotions of the crowd, bending it to his will. This makes the film less a study of racism than of the exercise of power for its own sake, and Cramer is like a

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Roger Corman: Hollywood's Wild Angel + Roger Corman at the NFT
Mon 19 Oct 18:30; Wed 4 Nov 20:30
Machine Gun Kelly
Mon 19 Oct 20:40; Sat 14 Nov 12:20
The Masque of the Red Death
Tue 20 Oct 18:30; Sat 31 Oct 20:50; Fri 27 Nov 18:15
House of Usher (aka The Fall of the House of Usher)
Tue 20 Oct 20:45; Sat 14 Nov 14:45 (+ intro by Julie Corman, producer and Roger Corman's wife)
A Bucket of Blood
Wed 21 Oct 21:00; Fri 13 Nov 20:50 (+ intro by Mary Corman, Roger Corman's daughter); Sun 22 Nov 12:00
The Wild Angels
Thu 22 Oct 18:20; Sun 1 Nov 15:00; Thu 12 Nov 20:30 (+ intro by Catherine Corman, Roger Corman's daughter)
The Terror
Thu 22 Oct 20:50; Fri 20 Nov 18:35
The Little Shop of Horrors
Sat 24 Oct 20:30; Sun 15 Nov 15:30
The Pit and the Pendulum
Sun 25 Oct 15:40; Thu 19 Nov 20:50; Mon 30 Nov 18:20
The Intruder
Sun 25 Oct 18:20; Fri 13 Nov 18:10 (+ intro by Julie Corman, producer and Roger Corman's wife); Tue 17 Nov 21:00
X: The Man with X-Ray Eyes
Tue 27 Oct 18:30; Mon 23 Nov 21:00
The St. Valentine's Day Massacre
Fri 30 Oct 20:50; Thu 19 Nov 18:20
The Raven
Sat 31 Oct 16:10; Sun 22 Nov 18:00
Attack of the Crab Monsters
Mon 2 Nov 20:55; Sat 21 Nov 18:30
Roger Corman's Frankenstein Unbound
Thu 5 Nov 20:45; Sun 29 Nov 18:30
The Trip: Director's Cut
Wed 18 Nov 20:55; Thu 26 Nov 18:40

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walking cypher from period studies of the 'Authoritarian Personality'. Where this leaves the film as a 'serious-type drama', or a lecture, about racial prejudice is unclear. In this sense, the drama devolves on a secondary character, newspaper editor Tom McDaniel (Frank Maxwell), whose reluctant support for desegregation because it is now law undergoes a sea change to moral conviction. In the process he suffers a savage beating – the necessary Calvary for many a Hollywood hero – and loses an eye. This would make him a true Corman hero, or at least a hero to set against those true Corman villains (and Cramer, in his dark glasses, is clearly kin to Vincent Price in this respect), megalomaniacs and shutaways, whose vision is always shielded against the light. For the rest, treatment of the racial issue at times suggests – though this is more explicit in Charles Beaumont's novel – that if it weren't for outside agitators like Cramer the 'good' white element in town would eventually outweigh the few bad apples and accept their Black brothers (a familiar argument, which ignores institutionalised racism).

Beaumont's novel, in fact, is very revealing of much that is hidden in the film: the suppressed links between Cramer and the anti-segregation cause. The film is actually a very faithful adaptation of the novel, taking almost every scene and line of dialogue word-for-word from its source. But this fidelity, along with the film's scrupulous documentary look, is what leaves the sense that its heart is hidden. There's a coldness at its core that again is a familiar Corman mood, springing from the kind of psychological history that Beaumont's book supplies. Here the making of a monster is spelled out: Cramer's rearing by an over-protective mother and a father who scorned him for being 'sickly', combined with an actual childhood illness that 'stole away the man who might have been and put a wrinkled mummy in his place.'

In his search for compensating father figures, and a confident identity, Cramer latches on to a university professor who preaches scorn for the masses and the necessity for the strong individual to seize and wield power. (This idol too turns out to have feet of clay: when Cramer starts putting his theories into practice in Caxton, he turns up to beg him to stop, fearful of his academic position – it was all a 'game', he didn't mean it; a development which, along with the explicit homosexuality, bears interesting comparison with Hitchcock's *Rope*.) In this light, it is no wonder that Beaumont went on to script three Poe adaptations for Corman (including *The Masque of the Red Death*), and *The Intruder* might be seen as an 'unnatural' attempt to bring such Gothic material into the contemporary open air. But for this reason it also looks like a crucial Corman film, revealing so much by suppressing so much, not least how even his most socially conscious films (from *Teenage Cavemen*, perhaps, to *The Wild Angels*) must always work in a psychological, Freudian, even Poe-like vein.

Richard Combs, *Monthly Film Bulletin*, July 1990